

Pre-Offer Construction Checklist for Buyers

What buyers should look for at the showing — and what they should price into the offer before the inspection. From a licensed NC General Contractor. Use this BEFORE writing the offer so the price reflects construction reality.

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How to use this checklist

Most buyers form their construction read from the inspection — by then the offer is in, earnest money is at risk, and the conversation is reactive. This checklist lets you read the property at the showing and shape the offer to reflect what you see. **The goal isn't to inspect the house yourself** — it's to know what to expect, what to price in, and what's a walk-away.

Section 1 — At the curb (60 seconds)

Quick signals can	
■	Roof line straight, no obvious sag or visible damage
■	Gutters attached and not bent or rotted
■	Foundation visible — no horizontal cracks, no visible bowing
■	Driveway and walkway intact (cosmetic only is fine)
■	Trim and paint not actively peeling (FHA/VA flag if peeling)
■	Trees within 15 feet of structure — note for future cost
■	Drainage: ground slopes away from foundation, no pooling spots
■	Neighboring lots — note any obvious construction or future-build risk

Section 2 — Walking the interior

In side, look for	
	■ Cracks at door frames or above windows — settlement signal
	■ Stains on ceilings (roof leak or upstairs plumbing)
	■ Sloping or bouncy floors — structural read needed
	■ Sticky doors and windows — house may be settling unevenly
	■ Musty smells in basement or crawlspace — water intrusion history
	■ Mismatched paint or recently-repainted patches — covering damage?
	■ Fresh caulking around tub/shower — recent leak repair?
	■ Visible water staining under sinks, behind toilet, near washer hookup

Section 3 — Age-based red flags by major system

When the listing or seller indicates a system's age, here's how to think about it:

System	Useful life	Concern threshold	Price into offer
Asphalt roof	20–25 yrs	Year 15+	\$8K–22K replacement
HVAC system	12–18 yrs	Year 10+	\$8K–14K replacement
Water heater (tank)	8–12 yrs	Year 6+	\$1,200–2,500 replacement
Electrical panel	40+ yrs (newer)	Pre-1990 or under 100A	\$2,500–5,000 upgrade
Plumbing (copper/PEX)	50+ yrs	Galvanized still in place	\$6K–18K repipe
Septic system	25–40 yrs	Year 20+ or unknown	\$8K–25K replacement
Windows (single-pane)	indefinite	Anytime — efficiency only	\$400–1,200 per window
Original siding (15+ yrs)	varies	Visible damage	\$8K–25K replacement

Section 4 — What an inspection won't catch

Even a thorough home inspection has blind spots. Be aware of these before the offer:

In s p e c t i o n b l i n d s p o t s	
■	Inside walls (rot, mold, hidden damage)
■	Behind appliances and cabinets (water staining, pest activity)
■	Sewer lateral condition (sewer scope is a separate \$250–400 service)
■	Septic drain field health (separate evaluation needed)
■	Underground oil tanks (require special detection)
■	Mold in HVAC ductwork (requires specialty inspection)
■	Roof underlayment condition (only visible during replacement)
■	Foundation work that was patched cosmetically

Section 5 — Walk-away triggers

Some items should make you reconsider the whole deal. These are usually deal-killers unless the price reflects them:

R e c o n s i d e r t h e d e a l i f y o u s e	
■	Active foundation movement (recent crack progression, visible bowing)
■	Mold visible in living areas or HVAC system
■	Galvanized plumbing in the entire house (full repipe cost)
■	Knob-and-tube electrical with insurance refusal flag
■	Multiple major systems all at end of life simultaneously
■	Past water intrusion that wasn't remediated professionally
■	Permits never pulled for major past renovations
■	Property in known flood zone without proper insurance review

Section 6 — Pre-offer price-impact math

Rule of thumb when condition is uncertain: **price the offer at list minus expected Year-1 repair cost**. The buyer will spend that money regardless — better to price it into the offer than to be surprised post-close.

■ List price minus rough Year-1 repair budget = your max offer

■ Items past expected useful life = factor at full replacement cost

■ Items mid-life = factor at 30–50% of replacement cost

■ Items recently updated = factor at zero

■ Always leave 10–15% buffer for inspection surprises

When you want a GC-backed read on a specific property

Southern Cities offers a Buyer-Side Property Read — a licensed GC reads the property from photos and listing data BEFORE the offer goes in, gives you the construction-side perspective, and recommends offer strategy. \$299, 1-business-day turnaround.

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